

What are dinosaurs?

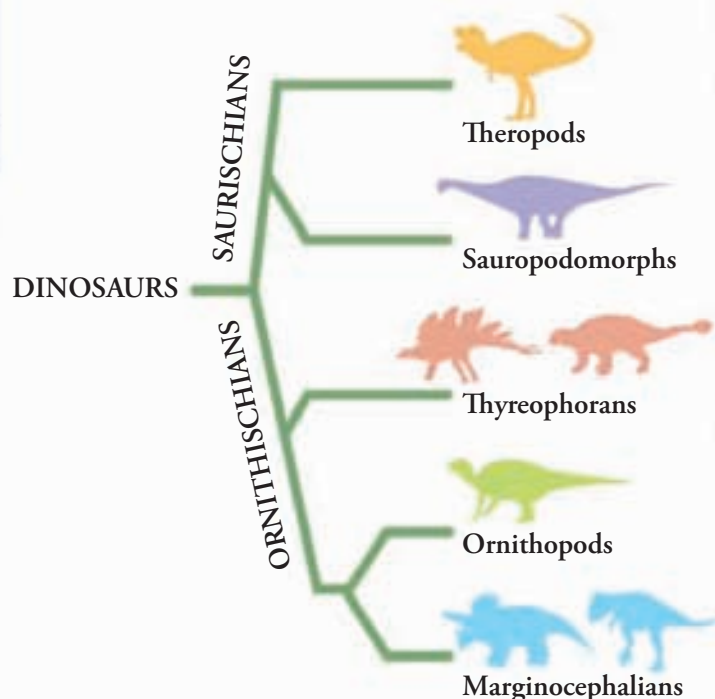
Dinosaurs survived for an astounding 160 million years (humans, in contrast, have existed for less than one million years). Ranging in size from animals no bigger than pigeons to lumbering giants the size of a truck, they were reptiles, but very different from modern-day reptiles.



◀ WE'RE STILL HERE! Most scientists believe that birds are the living descendants of small, meat-eating dinosaurs.

FAMILY TREE

Dinosaurs can be split into two groups: the saurischians (or lizard-hipped dinosaurs) and the ornithischians (or bird-hipped dinosaurs). These can be split further, as shown below.



FACT FILE

Key features

- Lived on land
- Built nests and laid eggs
- Most had scaly skin (some had feathers)
- Long tails, held off the ground
- Walked on upright, pillarlike legs.
- Holes ("windows") in the skulls of larger dinosaurs, making them lighter. (Only the armored dinosaurs had solid skulls.)
- Walked on their toes
- Claws on fingers and toes

One way in which dinosaurs differed from today's reptiles and lizards is that they could stand with their legs straight, in the same way as mammals. Some dinosaurs walked on two legs, some on four. Some may have done both.



▲ DINOSAURS walked on upright, pillarlike legs.



▲ CROCODILES walked with knees and elbows bent.



▲ LIZARDS hold their legs at right-angles to the body.

THYREOPHORANS (THIGH-ree-OFF-oh-rans)

Also called armored dinosaurs, members of this group of plant-eaters were large, walked on four feet, and had armor plates and spikes that protected them from attack. Some of these dinosaurs even had armored eyelids!



◀ KENTROSAURUS had a double row of bony plates running along the center of its back.